insufficient water from achieving high levels of multi-crop production, were compelled to pursue plundering expeditions with fighting skills honed by turbulent relations with herdsmen and forest people. The Reddis and Velamas of Andhra and Vanniyars of Tamil country exemplify such warlike peasantries'. It didn't help, writes Stein, that 'the superior cavalry and archery of [northern] Muslim fighters intensified this emerging martial quality, gave it an edge that doomed the older, more prosperous areas of agriculture and settlement in the river valleys to political subordination and plunder'.

Vijayanagar too was an upland peninsular settlement, very much on the frontier of the expansionist Muslim rule. As the Sangama warrior brothers and their progeny began expanding Vijayanagar's realm in the south, they fortified their dominance through new innovations. Most notably, they appointed a cadre of governors, or *nayak*s, across their realm, to assert the king's authority and extract regional rents.[17] These imperial governors—comprising dozens of trusted royal kin, noblemen and military generals—either had sole and direct authority in some regions or worked through semi-autonomous local chiefs in others. Some governors funnelled up half of their tax revenue to the king, while others kept more of it and grew quite powerful, which created its own problems.

Taxes also came from trading ports—likely sizeable since major roads linked their capital to ports on both the Malabar and Coromandel coasts, and military guards ensured the smooth flow of goods on them, including Arabian war horses (every year, writes Nuniz, the king of Vijayanagar imported 13,000 horses from Hormuz, besides others from Aden). The largest taxpayers in Vijayanagar Empire were traders, merchants, and industrial producers. Their economic importance is evident from these words by Krishnadevaraya:

> A king should improve the harbours of his country and so encourage its commerce . . . make the merchants of distant foreign countries who import elephants and good horses attached to yourself by providing them with villages and decent dwellings in the city, by affording them daily audience, presents and allowing decent profits. Then those articles will never go to your enemies.[18]

What soon began emerging was a centralized state that was further fine-tuned in the early sixteenth century by Krishnadevaraya, reaching its peak